

The River Answers Back: What the Numbers Hide

河流的回应：数字隐藏了什么

Theme: 环境、自然与可持续发展 · New: 44 · Review: 18 · Planned cumulative progress: 44/6, 127

English Story

The numbers hid the **water** itself. **Into** the file went a **well of** readings, a **bed of** sediment, and an **element of weather** that no instrument had recorded; the **atmosphere of** the field station was **almost** cheerful, and the **condition of** the **river** was not.

The **main product of** the **process** was a clean record **of** the wrong question. “We **give** the **river** a **channel** and call it data,” the boatman said. “The **land**, the **forest**, and the **native** trees are not in your table.” The **male** and **female** volunteers agreed on that, and the **food** for the meeting was an **eggplant** stew.

The **root of** the problem was a **lock** on the model: only one kind **of** evidence could get in. A **stream of dust** from the **dock**, a **pot of cotton**, and a **mineral** sample in a **pad of wax**: the **craft of** the old survey was precise and blind to the **river bed**.

The **spray** from the **washing of** the **trap**, the **rip** in the **organ** pipe, and the **screw** that nobody could find: the **establishment** had replaced a measurement **with** a maintenance schedule. “We are **against** the **light of** a single number,” Maya said.

The **calling of** the volunteers was to look at the **earth** and the **ocean** in the same hour, **with** the same **need** to know and the same willingness to be wrong. A **rib of** the old dam, a **gum** tree, and a **calorie** table were not enough to explain a flood.

While the report was being written, the **river** went down and came back up. The numbers hid that too, and the group agreed to publish the whole page, **similar** in shape to the first one but **with** a **ground** line at the bottom. The **dust**, the **pot**, the **pad**, and the **spray**: all **of** it was ours. “The **river** gives **us** the question,” the boatman said, “and the **establishment** gives **us** the form.” The **stream**, the **lock**, the **dock**, and the **trap** were all in the same chapter, and the **craft of** the survey was to see them together. The **air**, the **star**, and the **nature of** the **river** were not in the **drug of** a single number; **either** we **play** fairly or we do not **play** at all.

中文翻译

这些数字掩盖了水本身。一口井的读数、一层沉积物，以及一个没有任何仪器记录过的天气要素，都被放进了文件；野外站的气氛几乎是愉快的，而河流的状况不是。

这个流程的主要产物是一份关于错误问题的干净记录。“我们给河一条河道，然后称之为数据，”船夫说，“土地、森林和本地树种都不在你的表里。”男女志愿者都同意这一点，会上的食物是一锅茄子。

问题的根源是模型上的一把锁：只有一种证据进得来。从码头吹来一阵尘土、一罐棉花，以及一块封在蜡垫里的矿物样本：旧勘测的技艺很精确，却对河床视而不见。

陷阱清洗时的水花、风琴管上的一道裂口，以及谁也找不到的那颗螺丝：这个机构已经用一份维护日程替换了一次测量。“我们反对单一数字的那束光，”曼雅说。

志愿者的使命是在同一个小时里看土地和海洋，怀着同样的求知需要，以及同样愿意出错的意愿。旧坝的一根肋骨、一棵橡胶树和一张热量表，都不足以解释一场洪水。

报告还在写的时候，河水落下又涨了回来。数字把这一点也掩盖了，而小组同意把整页都公布出来——形状与第一页相似，但底部多了一条基准线。那些尘土、那口锅、那个垫子和那阵水花：全都是我们的。“河流给我们问题，”船夫说，“而机构给我们表格。”那条溪流、那座水闸、那个码头和那个陷阱，都在同一章里，而调查的技艺就是把它们放在一起看。空气、星星和这条河的本性，都不在单一数字的药剂里；要么我们公平地玩，要么我们根本不玩。

Core Vocabulary · 核心词汇

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
into 'ɪntu: POS: prep	prep. 进入...之内, 朝..., 深入...之中, 成为...状况 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: prep. To the inside of; within. It is used in a variety of; applications.; prep. Expressing entrance, or a p...
well wel POS: n	n. 井, 泉水, 源泉, 好; v. 涌出; a. 健康的, 良好的, 适宜的, 恰当的; adv. 很好地, 适当地, 好意地, 很, 完全... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a deep hole or shaft dug or drilled to obtain water or oil or gas or brine; n. a cavity or vessel used to c...
us ʌs POS: pron	pron. 我们; [经] 美国 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n North American republic containing 50 states – 48 conterminous states in North America plus Alaska in north...
water 'wɔ:tə POS: n	n. 水, 雨水, 海水, 水位, 水面, 流水; vt. 给...浇水, 供以水, 注入水, 使湿; vi. 流泪, 流口水, 加水; a. ... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. binary compound that occurs at room temperature as a clear colorless odorless tasteless liquid; freezes in...
process 'prɒses POS: n	n. 程序, 进行, 过程; vt. 加工, 使...接受处理, 对...处置, 对...起诉; a. 经加工的, 有特殊光效的; [计] 进程 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. (psychology) the performance of some composite cognitive activity; an operation that affects mental conten...
air eə POS: n	n. 空气, 旋律, 态度; vt. 晾, 使通风, 夸耀 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a mixture of gases (especially oxygen) required for breathing; the stuff that the wind consists of; n. the...
land lənd POS: n	n. 陆地, 地面, 地界, 地产, 国土, 土地; vi. 登陆, 登岸, 到达; vt. 使上岸, 使登陆, 使到达; [计] 连接盘; 焊盘 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the land on which real estate is located; n. material in the top layer of the surface of the earth in which...
star stɑ: POS: n	n. 星, 恒星, 星形物, 运气, 明星; vt. 以星状物装饰, 用星号标, 使成为明星; vi. 变成明星 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. (astronomy) a celestial body of hot gases that radiates energy derived from thermonuclear reactions in the...
nature 'neɪtʃə POS: n	n. 自然, 大自然, 本性, 性格, 性质; [医] 自然, 大自然; 本性, 性能 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the essential qualities or characteristics by which something is recognized; n. a causal agent creating and...
bed bed POS: n	n. 床, 睡眠处, 河床, 底座, 路基, 一层; vt. 提供宿处, 栽种, 安装; vi. 睡, 形成坚实的一层 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a piece of furniture that provides a place to sleep; n. a plot of ground in which plants are growing; n. a d...
element 'elɪmənt POS: n	n. 元件, 元素, 要素; [计] 部分; 成分; 单元; 码元; 元件; 元素; 单元 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the most favorable environment for a plant or animal; n. one of four substances thought in ancient and medi...
river 'rɪvə POS: n	n. 河, 江; [法] 河流, 江河, 内河 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a large natural stream of water (larger than a creek)
earth ə:θ POS: n	n. 地球, 泥土, 世界, 尘世; vt. 埋入土中, 赶入洞内; vi. 躲入洞内 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the 3rd planet from the sun; the planet we live on; n. the loose soft material that makes up a large part o...
forest 'fɒrɪst POS: n	n. 森林, 林区; vt. 植树于 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the trees and other plants in a large densely wooded area; n. land that is covered with trees and shrubs
male meɪl POS: n	n. 男人, 雄性动物; a. 男性的, 雄性的, 有力的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an animal that produces gametes (spermatozoa) that can fertilize female gametes (ova); n. a person who belo...
female 'fi:meɪl POS: n	n. 女性, 女人, 雌性动物; a. 女性的, 女子的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an animal that produces gametes (ova) that can be fertilized by male gametes (spermatozoa); n. a person who...
native 'neɪtɪv POS: n	n. 本地人, 土产, 当地人; a. 本国的, 与生俱来的, 自然的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an indigenous person who was born in a particular place; n. a person born in a particular place or country; ...
weather 'weðə POS: n	n. 天气, 气象, 处境; a. 迎风的; vt. 使受风吹雨打, 侵蚀, 使风化, 经受住; vi. 风化, 受侵蚀, 经受风雨 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the atmospheric conditions that comprise the state of the atmosphere in terms of temperature and wind and...
channel 'tʃænel POS: n	n. 海峡, 航道, 频道; vt. 引导, 在...上挖沟, 形成河道; [计] 信道, 通道 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a path over which electrical signals can pass; n. a passage for water (or other fluids) to flow through; n. ...

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
root ru:t POS: n	n. 根, 根本, 根源, 基础, 底部; vt. 使扎根, 使固定, 根除, 肃清, 搜出, 用鼻拱; vi. 生根, 固定, 源于, 用鼻... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. (botany) the usually underground organ that lacks buds or leaves or nodes; absorbs water and mineral salts...
ocean 'əʊjən POS: n	n. 海洋, 广阔, 许多, 一大片; [法] 海洋, 海 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a large body of water constituting a principal part of the hydrosphere; n. anything apparently limitless in...
atmosphere 'ætməsfiə POS: n	n. 大气, 空气, 气氛; [医] 大气; 大气压 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a particular environment or surrounding influence; n. the mass of air surrounding the Earth; n. the weather...
establishment i'stæblɪmənt POS: n	n. 确立, 制定, 设施; [经] 企业, 公司, 商店 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a public or private structure (business or governmental or educational) including buildings and equipment...
lock lɒk POS: n	n. 锁, 刹车, 水闸, 一缕头发; vt. 锁, 锁上, 拘禁, 隐藏, (用锁等)拴住, 刹住; vi. 锁住, (齿轮等)啮合, (船... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a fastener fitted to a door or drawer to keep it firmly closed; n. a strand or cluster of hair; n. a mechan...
stream stri:m POS: n	n. 水流, 小河, 流出, 趋势, 人潮; vt. 流出, 流动, 展开; vi. 流, 涌, 飘扬; [计] 流 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a natural body of running water flowing on or under the earth; n. dominant course (suggestive of running wa...
pot pɒt POS: n	n. 盆, 罐, 壶, 坩埚, 奖杯; vt. 装入盆中, 在锅中煮, 随手射击; vi. 随手射击 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. metal or earthenware cooking vessel that is usually round and deep; often has a handle and lid; n. the quan...
dust dʌst POS: n	n. 灰尘, 尘埃, 粉末, 花粉, 土, 骚乱; vt. 拂去灰尘, 撒, 弄成粉末; vi. 拂去灰尘, 化为粉末 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. fine powdery material such as dry earth or pollen that can be blown about in the air; n. free microscopic p...
craft kræft POS: n	n. 技艺, 手艺, 诡计; vt. 精心制作 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a vehicle designed for navigation in or on water or air or through outer space; n. people who perform a par...
organ 'ɔ:ɡən POS: n	n. 风琴, 器官, 元件, 机构, 机关; [电] 风琴 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a fully differentiated structural and functional unit in an animal that is specialized for some particular...
cotton 'kɒtn POS: n	n. 棉花; vi. 和谐, 有好感, 理解 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. soft silky fibers from cotton plants in their raw state; n. fabric woven from cotton fibers; n. erect bushy...
mineral 'mɪnərəl POS: n	n. 矿物, 无机物, 苏打水; a. 矿物的, 似矿物的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. solid homogeneous inorganic substances occurring in nature having a definite chemical composition; a. relat...
trap træp POS: n	n. 圈套, 陷阱, 诡计, 存水弯; vi. 设圈套, 设陷阱; vt. 诱捕, 诱骗, 抓住, 使受限制; [计] 俘获; 陷井 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a device in which something (usually an animal) can be caught and penned; n. drain consisting of a U-shaped...
dock dɒk POS: n	n. 码头, 船坞, 被告席, 尾巴的骨肉部分; vt. 使靠码头, 使(船)进港, 剪短; vi. 进港 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an enclosure in a court of law where the defendant sits during the trial; n. any of certain coarse weedy pl...
rip rɪp POS: n	n. 裂痕, 破绽, 拉裂, 浪子, 巨浪; vi. 被拉开, 裂开, 猛冲; vt. 撕, 扯, 劈 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an opening made forcibly as by pulling apart; n. a stretch of turbulent water in a river or the sea caused...
pad pæd POS: n	n. 填补, 衬垫, 印色盒, 路; vt. 填补, 走, 夸大; vi. 步行; [计] 焊接点; 包装配/拆卸 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a number of sheets of paper fastened together along one edge; n. the large floating leaf of an aquatic plan...
washing 'wɒʃɪŋ POS: n	n. 洗涤, 浸, 洗涤物; [机] 涂浆, 洗涤 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n the work of cleansing (usually with soap and water); n garments or white goods that can be cleaned by launde...
spray spreɪ POS: n	n. 水沫, 浪花, 水花, 喷雾, 喷雾器, 小树枝; vt. 喷雾, 扫射, 喷射; vi. 喷, 溅开 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a pesticide in suspension or solution; intended for spraying; n. a quantity of small objects flying through...
rib rɪb POS: n	n. 肋骨, 肋状物, 笑话; vt. 装肋状物于, 戏弄 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. support resembling the rib of an animal; n. any of the 12 pairs of curved arches of bone extending from the...
screw skru: POS: n	n. 螺旋, 螺杆, 螺钉, 螺旋桨, 吝啬鬼; vt. 调节, 扭紧, 旋, 拧, 加强, 压榨, 勒索; vi. 转动, 旋, 拧 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a simple machine of the inclined-plane type consisting of a spirally threaded cylindrical rod that engages...

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
gum gʌm POS: n	n. 树胶, 橡皮, 橡皮糖, 牙床, 老天; vt. 涂以树胶, 用胶粘, 使有粘性; vi. 分泌树胶, 发粘 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. any of various substances (soluble in water) that exude from certain plants; they are gelatinous when mois...
wax wæks POS: n	n. 蜡, 蜡状物, 一阵发怒, 增加, (月亮)渐盈; vi. 变大, 增大, 月亮渐满; vt. 上蜡于 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. any of various substances of either mineral origin or plant or animal origin; they are solid at normal tem...
calling ˈkɔ:lɪŋ POS: n	n. 职业, 行业, 呼唤, 召集; [计] 呼叫 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n the particular occupation for which you are trained; v assign a specified (usually proper) proper name to; v...
eggplant ˈegplɑ:nt POS: n	n. 茄子 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. egg-shaped vegetable having a shiny skin typically dark purple but occasionally white or yellow; n. hairy u...
calorie ˈkæləri POS: n	n. 卡路里 (热量单位) Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a unit of heat equal to the amount of heat required to raise the temperature of one kilogram of water by o...